7.7 More than a funeral, the protection of tumuli in Hungary

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Introduction

Based on Hungarian practice since 2010, preliminary archaeological documentation should be prepared before large-scale developments. This documentation process can be divided into different phases depending on the nature of projects. Risk analyses are carried out as the first phase of documentation in cases of long-term development – for example new motorways, bypass roads or industrial parks. This phase consists of data collection and classification of known archaeological sites. The following four categories are used for classification:

- Risk 1 has impact which threatens the realisation of the investment, in this case the impact reduction strategy is avoidance. Legally-protected archaeological sites and architectural heritage features preserved in situ belong to this category.
- Risk 2 may endanger the realization of the investment or require a lot of costs and time, so the risk management is also avoidance. This situation applies to sites where there is potential for archaeological elements to emerge which need preserving.
- Risk 3 does not endanger the realization of the investment, but it requires costs and time. Therefore, preventive excavation is used to reduce the impact. In these cases full-surface excavations are employed.
- Risk 4 has minimal cost and time requirements, the risk management means archaeological observation, which is the other type of preventive excavation.

In the next phase non-destructive methods are carried out, firstly with field surveys. At this time the project is still in the design stage, and it is possible to make particular adjustments. Certain types or parts could be avoided depend on the importance of the archaeological sites – especially built heritage, such as a Roman villa, a medieval church ruin and surrounding cemetery, tumulus, hillfort or other types of monuments.

There are thousands of tumuli [kurgans] in Hungary dating from the Late Copper Age to the Roman period. The first appearance of these phenomena in the Late Copper Age/Early Bronze Age (3400-2800 BC), was connected to the nomadic peoples of the Yamnaja culture who came from Central Asia. The medieval Kun population was the last community to build mounds in the Great Hungarian Plain, but these can be found in smaller numbers. Many of the mounds have been ploughed up or partially removed due to material extraction. For example, of the 366 mounds known from the Százhalom site in Százhalombatta which surround the Middle Bronze Age to Late Iron Age fortified settlement, many are now only visible on geophysical surveys or aerial photographs, because of agricultural cultivation.

These cultural monuments are not simply graves or archaeological sites, but complex phenomena that are associated with historical legends, folk traditions and beliefs. They stand as landmarks next to streams, ancient roads, along old and occasionally still existing borders (e.g. settlement or county borders). They were also popularly used in later periods as communal or ritual places, mainly for burial purposes, and often churches were built on them during the Árpádian Age. Although there are single kurgans, most of them are in pairs, or in small, loose groups, in line, or dense groupings. It is common to find one or more smaller kurgans next to a taller one. The importance of the tumuli for nature conservation – primarily botanical – is also outstanding, as valuable plant associations and ancient steppe vegetation (species-rich loess vegetation) have survived on the surface of the less disturbed kurgans.

In many cases of large-scale developments, the planning areas contain kurgans which can be easily identified with the naked eye. But although the mounds often have landscape significance, most of them do not enjoy outstanding or enhanced archaeological protection.

Short description of the legal system

There is a long tradition of cultural heritage regulation in Hungary, with the first law on the protection of historical monuments dating back to 1881. In the Act of 1929, there is the first mention of prohibited areas: those significant archaeological sites where excavations can only be carried out under appropriate conditions. The current Act on the Protection of Cultural Heritage and its accompanying regulations were adopted in 2001 and have undergone several amendments since then. According to the regulation archaeological sites can be classified into three categories: protected sites (with outstanding or enhanced significance), registered sites and potential sites (Fig.35). Protected sites are subject to additional legal procedures to registered sites: they are identified, verified by professional tools and entered in the central, official register and are subject to general protection by the force of law. Nearly 3% of the registered sites in Hungary are protected .

The Act on Nature Conservation (1996) also provides protection for earthworks, tumuli and caves (e.g. the register contains 1548 tumuli), most of which, however, are not subject to archaeological protection.

The most important instrument for determining significance in the past decades has been the declaration of a site as protected, whereby scientific documentation of the site's values was prepared, followed by a proposal to classify the site to outstanding (national-international significance) or to enhance protection category (regional significance). The reinforcement of protection through legal instruments ensured that these sites should be avoided by developments. A protection strategy was developed in the early 2000s, identifying the most important types of sites: 1.Prehistoric settlements, 2.Prehistoric and Early Middle Age fortifications, 3.Prehistoric and Roman Age burial mounds, 4.Roman Age forts, medieval castles, 5.Roman and medieval towns, 6.Roman Age villas, 7.Medieval churches, monasteries, other stone buildings, 8.Other sites (e.g. settlements of the Migration Period or the Middle Ages, cemeteries with particularly large number of grave goods, etc.).

The following criteria were taken into account during the evaluation: the uniqueness of the archaeological/historical value, its place among similar archaeological monuments of the period, the existence of one or more periods, its rarity, its extent, its richness of finds, its vulnerability to erosion and its tourist attractiveness. In justified cases, archaeological buffer zones and/or option for public pre-emption were determined. However, the importance of the archaeological sites was evaluated on a case-by-case basis and the protection categories (regional or national importance) are not clarified in a transparent evaluation system.

Since the second half of the 2010s, the role and function of the protection has been declining, with no new protection decree since 2017. The 2018 regulation extended the circle of sites that should not be disturbed by developments: in addition to sites declared protected, sites of registered landscape importance and archaeological monuments/architectural heritage features preserved in situ in their original context without physical deterioration should be avoided by investments (Figs.36 & 37).

A new archaeological strategy which is under elaboration, also indicates that the designation-protection and classification of sites must be based on a new basis, taking into account the aspects of social benefit. This case study illustrates how preliminary archaeological documentation can help in the long-term preservation of significant sites.

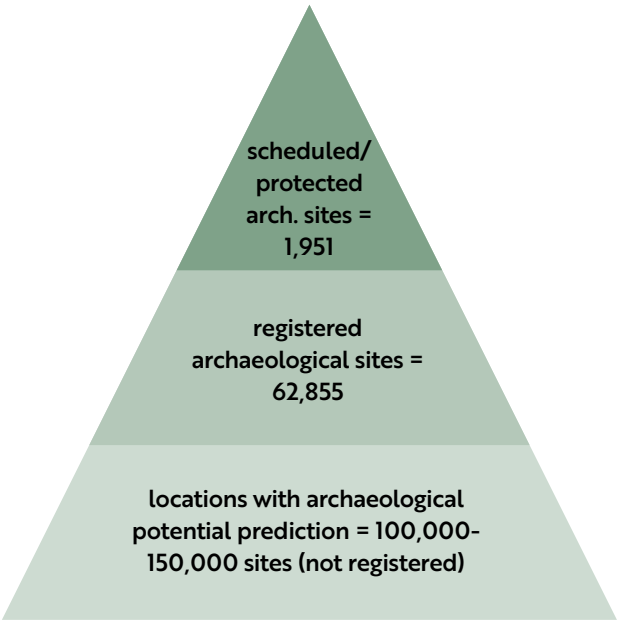

Figure 35: Site categories (prepared by K Wollák)

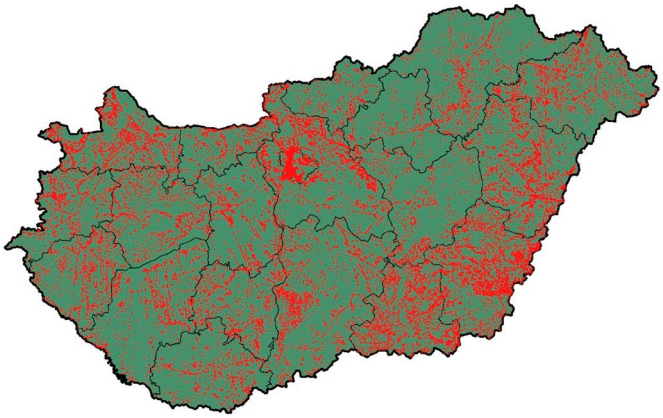

Figure 36: Registered Hungarian sites (prepared by L. Reményi).

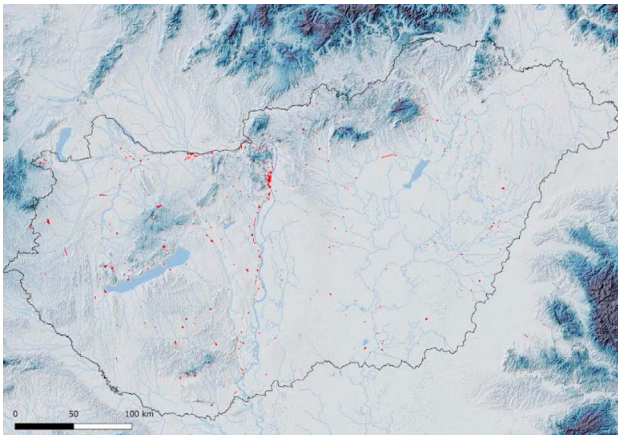

Figure 37: Protected Hungarian sites (prepared by A. Bödöcs).

Location and surroundings

The archaeological site, Füzesgyarmat – Bárdos-halom is situated on the Great Hungarian Plain, in the lowland, on the Dévaványa plain. This area is located between two rivers, the Hortobágy-Berettyó and the Körösök. The Bárdos-, or as it was formerly called Bárda-kurgan stands on the south-east bank of an ancient bend of the Berettyó river, now called Bárda-stream, in an agricultural area.

Most of the tumuli on the Great Hungarian Plain are built on the high banks of rivers and watercourses, often on the highest points of the waterless zones. So far, 74 kurgans are known from the Füzesgyarmat area, and 20 of them still have landscape importance.

Numerous tumuli surrounding the Bárdos-kurgan are lined up along the Bárda-stream (Fig.38).

Reasons for assessment

The planned track of the M47 motorway would have passed through the Bárdos-kurgan. Initially, a field survey of the sites affected by the infrastructure project examined the built heritage and archaeological sites of high archaeological risk, so that there was a chance to avoid them in the planning phase. In constant consultation with the designers, it was possible to modify the route of the track (Fig.39). Thanks for this protocol the planned road would avoid completely the kurgan itself.

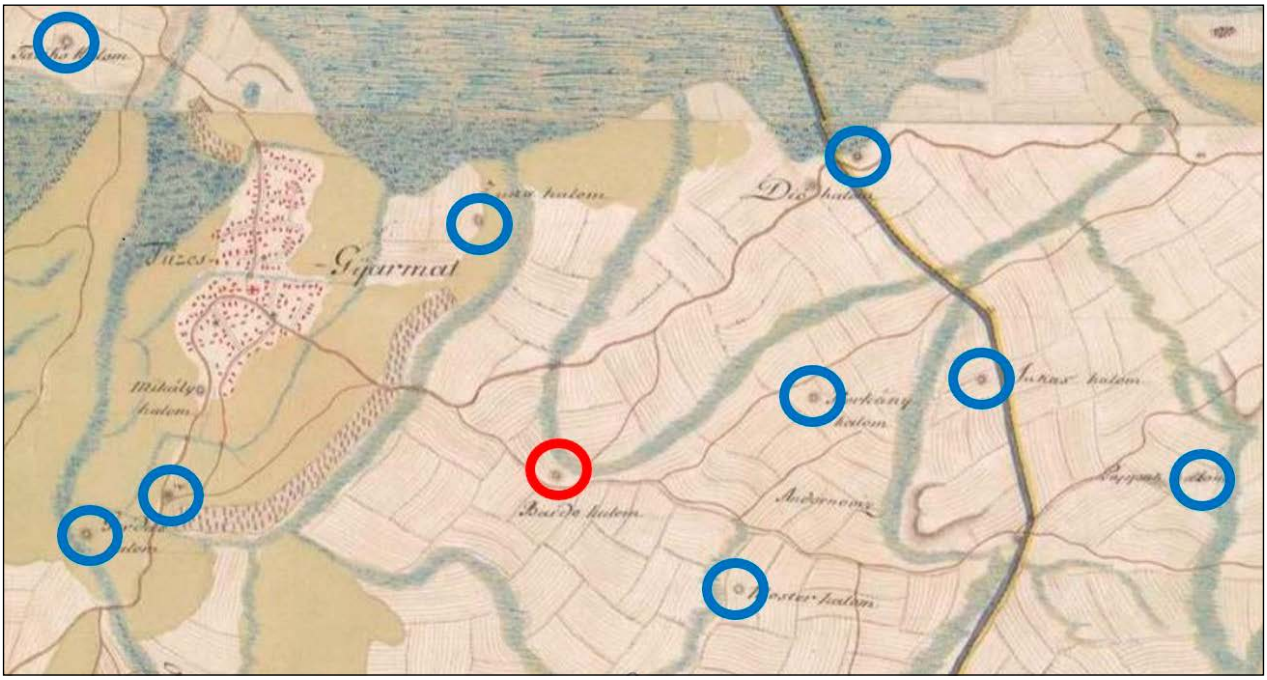

Figure 38: The Bárdos-kurgan and its surrounding area with other tumuli on the First Military Survey Maps (1782-85) (drawn by M. Koller)